SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES OF THE YOUTH ENTREPRENEURS OF AGUSAN DEL NORTE

A Thesis Presented To
The Faculty of
College of Business Management and Accountancy

In Partial Requirements for the Degree
Bachelor of Science in Business Administration
Major in Financial Management

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SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
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CERTIFICATE OF RESEARCH APPROVAL

This thesis entitled **"**Opportunities and Challenges of the Youth Entrepreneurs of Agusan del Norte**"** presented and submitted by College of Business Management and Accountancy in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science in Business Administration Major in Financial Management is hereby accepted and recommended for Oral Examination.

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ABSTRACT

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DESCRIPTIVE QUANTITATIVE

I. OBJECTIVES

This study will explore the opportunities and challenges faced by youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Specifically, it aims to identify the government programs and digital platforms available to these entrepreneurs and examine the challenges they encounter, such as limited access to capital, poor market access, and low financial literacy. Additionally, the study seeks to analyze the relationship between these opportunities and challenges to determine whether the available opportunities can help mitigate the difficulties faced by youth entrepreneurs.

II. METHODOLOGY

The study will employ a quantitative research approach using a descriptive research design. Data will be collected through a structured survey questionnaire, administered in person, targeting youth entrepreneurs aged 18 to 35 years in the three municipalities. A stratified random sampling method will be used to ensure diverse representation.

III. FINDINGS

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

KEYWORDS: XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Youth entrepreneurship has a significant impact on a nation's economy, employment growth, and overall progress (Boris & Parakhina, 2022). According to the International Labour Organization (ILO, 2022) young people are frequently viewed as "agents of change" who contribute their inventiveness, potential for picking up new skills, and willingness to take risks to the entrepreneurial ecosystem. (Youth Business International, 2024) states that assisting young people in launching their own businesses not only aids in their growth but also changes economies and communities. However, young entrepreneurs face significant challenges. They often face challenges such as funding issues, skill gaps, and social or cultural barriers (OECD/European Commission, 2023, pp. 49–51).

However, young entrepreneurs often face major challenges, particularly limited access to capital and low financial and business literacy. Research shows that economic and personal issues can stop young people from starting businesses. (Amouri et al., 2021) Highlight that funding is a main hurdle. It's hard for them to come up with ideas, launch, manage, and grow their businesses without enough money. Banks often deny loans to young owners. They often lack savings, collateral, or credit history (Youth Business International, 2024). Many new businesses fail or struggle to survive because of structural barriers like poor financial management, a lack of organizational capacity, and difficulties adapting to the market (Bethlendi et al., 2025). A lot of young people lack the confidence and business sense necessary to launch their own businesses. For instance, (Meng et al., 2023) discovered that although young Malaysian agropreneurs frequently exhibit inventiveness, they are deficient in the fundamental business and management abilities of organizing, planning, and managing money. According to FasterCapital (2025), business

owners who desire quick cash flow find it challenging to deal with inefficient support systems. They struggle to find patient capital, and funding processes are often too complex. Limited infrastructure and market access in rural areas make it tough for them to reach customers and compete. SpringerOpen (2024), in a study on micro-enterprises, researchers identified key challenges related to internationalization, including a lack of international market knowledge and difficult international marketing conditions. These barriers are reduced by digital presence, a resource often lacking in rural areas. The (Youth Co: Lab, 2024) report shows that bad infrastructure in rural areas holds back young entrepreneurs. It stresses the need for solutions to support them. Olalekan (2024) examines the opportunities and challenges of rural entrepreneurship in the context of digitalization. He notes that low digital literacy, bad internet access, and infrastructure problems are big challenges. Moreover, Batizani & Ronald Neva (2024) emphasize the need to expand the reach of government programs to underserved populations. While challenges persist, opportunities exist through digital finance and government support.

In the Philippines, youth entrepreneurship continues to face similar challenges. Reports indicate that limited access to funding and a lack of focus on areas outside Metro Manila hinder the potential of many youth entrepreneurs in the country (Manila Bulletin, 2024; International Trade Center study). To address these concerns, the government has implemented several programs, such as Republic Act No. 10679, or the Youth Entrepreneurship Act, which institutionalizes entrepreneurial education and provides training and mentorship opportunities for Filipino youth. Programs such as the Department of Trade and Industry's Youth Entrepreneurship Program (YEP) aim to equip out-of-school and aspiring young entrepreneurs with business skills and starter kits (DTI, 2023). Despite these initiatives, administrative challenges and inconsistent implementation continue to affect their effectiveness. The (International Trade Centre, 2023)

reports that administrative barriers and uneven implementation continue to constrain the effectiveness of youth entrepreneurship initiatives in the Philippines.

Furthermore, local government initiatives, which frequently supplement national programs, play a significant role in encouraging youth entrepreneurship. (Ndebele et al., 2022) highlight how equitable and sustainable business practices are promoted when local government support is combined with national initiatives. According to their findings, local initiatives like the OpportYouthnidad Caravan work well because they offer customized training and guidance based on the specific requirements of young business owners. But as Ferdousi et al. (2023) point out, local governments frequently deal with issues like corruption and a lack of funding, which prevent these programs from reaching their full potential. Future studies should focus on ways to better coordinate national and local initiatives to maximize effectiveness and ensure that young entrepreneurs receive consistent support throughout the entire business lifecycle.

This study looks at the chances and challenges for youth entrepreneurs in Agusan del Norte, focusing on the roles of government programs and digital platforms and tools, as well as the challenges of limited access to capital, poor market access and infrastructure, and low financial and business literacy. By identifying these factors, the study seeks to provide insights that can inform more effective policies and support mechanisms for young entrepreneurs in the province.

This study is significant because it contributes to a deeper understanding of the conditions affecting youth entrepreneurship; it provides valuable insights into opportunities and challenges faced by youth entrepreneurs in Agusan del Norte. The findings will help policymakers, educators, and development agencies in designing more responsive programs that enhance financial literacy, digital capability, and access to markets and capital. For youth entrepreneurs, this study provides practical insights that can guide their strategies and strengthen their participation in the local economy.

Review of Related Literature

This chapter reviews prior studies and relevant sectors, grounding the research in reliable academic foundations.

1.2 Related Literature

Understanding how to launch, run, and maintain a business is essential for anyone aspiring to become an entrepreneur. (Neneh, 2020), says the key to success is perseverance, smart choices, and spotting opportunities. Micro, small, and medium-sized enterprises (MSMEs) make up 99.5% of businesses in the Philippines. They provide over 63% of jobs. So, entrepreneurship through MSMEs drives inclusive growth in the country (RichestPH, 2025). The Magna Carta for MSMEs (RA 9501) and the Go Negosyo Act (RA 10644) create Negosyo Centers. These centers offer training, mentorship, and financial help. The government backs these efforts to support the industry. Only 10% of adults are entrepreneurs, but they create 70% of all jobs, according to (SGV & CO, 2024). This shows how vital they are for the nation's growth.

People see entrepreneurship as a way to become independent and help their communities grow. More young people are starting businesses. This shows their strong interest in innovation and independence (CIIT, 2023). Bouichou et al (2024) note that digital tools and social media enable business owners to respond to emerging trends and reach a wider audience. The definition of entrepreneurship is still debated in academic circles, even though it's important. Scholars say its definition changes based on social, psychological, and economic views. This makes it a dynamic concept (Favour Oluwadamilare Usman et al., 2024)

There is growing recognition of the potential of youth entrepreneurship to push local community development, particularly in underprivileged areas. According to Alzate et al. (2024), young entrepreneurs in developing nations use social innovation and digital tools to reach a wider audience and meet the needs of their local communities. These business owners are using

technology to develop solutions that support community development objectives in addition to broadening their market reach. Addressing societal issues and offering long-term business solutions requires the ability to blend innovation with community-focused projects.

The Be Your Own Boss (BYOB) model, introduced in the Philippines by the Department of Trade and Industry in partnership with USAID, provides out-of-school youth with targeted assistance by providing the resources and instruction they need to start and expand their businesses (opportunity.org, 2023). This program stresses the importance of mentorship, capital, and a supportive environment to help young entrepreneurs get past obstacles and grow their businesses. Programs like BYOB show that encouraging young people to start their own businesses can help build stronger communities and make them more resilient, in addition to giving them more economic power.

Furthermore, encouraging long-term economic sustainability and raising civic engagement require inclusive entrepreneurship. More inclusive entrepreneurship gives young people the chance to make a positive impact on their communities by generating employment, encouraging social change, and boosting self-reliance. Youth entrepreneurship has an impact that goes beyond financial gains, fostering civic engagement and a sense of responsibility that ultimately leads to more resilient societies.

Age

Age is a significant factor in shaping the entrepreneurial opportunities and challenges faced by young individuals. As Zhao et al. (2021) say, older entrepreneurs are often more mature, which helps them become better managers and build bigger networks. This experience that comes with age also increases their chances of long-term business success. Young business owners are often more creative and original. They are also more likely to take chances. But their businesses aren't stable because they don't have a lot of experience and

can't get formal financing. (Domingo, 2020) supports this by noting that senior high school students demonstrate high entrepreneurial intentions and social awareness but possess insufficient practical knowledge and business exposure. Similarly, (Etrata et al., 2022) observed that Filipino Generation Z entrepreneurs are highly business-minded and digitally skilled but require structured mentorship and plenty of resources to transform their enthusiasm into sustainable businesses.

The relationship between age and entrepreneurship also extends to the digital landscape. (Cueto et al., 2022) Younger entrepreneurs are more open to new digital technologies, especially when the economy is unstable. This lets them quickly adapt to new technologies. But this flexibility is limited by a lack of knowledge about the market, money management, and future planning. In Kenya, (Mwangi, 2024) backed up these results by showing that older youth entrepreneurs are more likely to use growth-oriented, strategic business models than younger ones. Age affects entrepreneurial strategy: younger entrepreneurs are more likely to start businesses that are based on technology and new ideas, while older entrepreneurs are more likely to work together and make their businesses last (Alzate et al., 2024).

In the Philippines, (Conception, 2021; opportunity.org, 2023) highlighted that entrepreneurship programs often fail when they overlook age-specific needs. Younger entrepreneurs benefit most from active learning, mentorship, and early-stage support, whereas older youth require enhanced access to finance, professional networks, and capacity-building opportunities to scale their ventures. Moreover, Firmin et al. (2022) emphasize that certain age groups of youth, especially those lacking stable family or social support systems, are more vulnerable to entrepreneurial failure during economic shocks or crises. Overall, these studies establish that age is a defining factor that both enables and constrains entrepreneurial success,

influencing innovation, adaptability, and sustainability among youth entrepreneurs across different environmental settings.

Gender

Gender plays a big role in access to business opportunities. It also affects the challenges young entrepreneurs face. (Senou & Manda, 2021) found a lasting gender gap in finance access for youth entrepreneurs in Benin. Female entrepreneurs face more barriers to credit and formal lending than males. These differences hold back women from growing their businesses. They also make it harder to access training programs that could boost their skills. Similarly, (Sargani et al., 2021) found that gender differences in Pakistan are deeply rooted in cultural and social structures. These structures shape entrepreneurial dreams from a young age. Their research highlighted that men are often motivated to engage in business ventures. Women encounter systemic barriers that restrict their involvement. This highlights how gender roles still affect entrepreneurship.

(Ochilova, 2021) Further observed that within family businesses, gender dynamics often determine ownership, leadership, and succession roles. Their findings highlight how female participation is frequently limited to supportive or informal positions rather than managerial or decision-making roles. These align with (Santos Silva & Klasen, 2021) theoretical review, which claims that gender inequality remains a significant barrier to economic growth, particularly in developing economies where women's entrepreneurial contributions are undervalued or overlooked. Together, these studies underscore that gender inequality not only shapes the entrepreneurial environment but also limits the overall economic potential of youth-led enterprises.

Men and women differ in motivation and in how they spot opportunities around the world. (Chauke & Obadire, 2020) found that many young women in South Africa start

businesses to survive. In contrast, young men tend to be motivated by growth opportunities. Wasilczuk and Karyy (2022) found that gender plays a big role in how young people in Eastern and Central Europe view entrepreneurship. Male youth are generally more confident and willing to take risks. In contrast, female youth tend to be more cautious and focused on their communities. Culture, resources, and support systems shape people's views on entrepreneurship. This perception varies by gender.

In addition to these observations, (Bouichou et al., 2021) studied youth in Moroccan agricultural cooperatives and reported that gender continues to determine entrepreneurial participation, with men dominating production and management roles, while women often engage in peripheral or informal business activities. Such disparities reflect the need for gender-responsive programs that recognize and support women's entrepreneurial potential within both urban and rural settings.

These studies show that gender greatly affects entrepreneurial experiences. It influences access to finance, role expectations, motivation, and social perceptions. Male youth often have more freedom, confidence, and support from institutions. Female youth face many barriers that limit their business growth and involvement in the formal economy. To tackle these differences, we need inclusive entrepreneurship programs. These programs should offer equal access to financial help and training. They must also challenge cultural norms that limit women's business growth.

Educational Attainment

Educational attainment and entrepreneurship education significantly shape the entrepreneurial intentions, competencies, and performance of young individuals. (Abulude & Ogunjemilua, 2025) Emphasized that formal entrepreneurship education enhances self-employment intentions by providing students with the knowledge, skills, and confidence

necessary to identify and develop business opportunities. Similarly, Bayar et al. (2022) found that higher levels of educational attainment are positively associated with entrepreneurial activity, particularly in high-income economies, where education not only fosters innovation and risk management but also increases access to professional networks and resources. These findings suggest that education acts as a foundation for entrepreneurial success, improving young entrepreneurs' ability to adapt to competitive market conditions.

Education also serves as a determinant of entrepreneurial intention and preparedness. In the Philippines, (Keoy et al., 2022) discovered that higher education students' entrepreneurial intentions are significantly influenced by exposure to entrepreneurship courses and institutional support. Students with greater access to entrepreneurship programs demonstrated stronger confidence and readiness to start a business, indicating that education systems play a critical role in nurturing entrepreneurial mindsets. Researchers have shown that large-scale youth entrepreneurship programs boost business knowledge and motivation. Structured educational programs build entrepreneurial skills in young people (Kim et al., 2020).

The relationship between entrepreneurship education and technological capability has also become increasingly important. (Pham et al., 2023) Reported that entrepreneurship knowledge contributes to the formation of e-entrepreneurial intentions, particularly when moderated by technological innovativeness. Their findings highlight how education not only builds entrepreneurial intention but also strengthens digital adaptability, a critical skill in modern business environments. (J. Sun et al., 2023) found that mindset, motivation, and prior exposure to entrepreneurship explain the relationship between education and entrepreneurial intention, suggesting that the quality of the educational experience matters as much as educational attainment (Wang et al., 2023) Found that mindset, motivation, and prior exposure to

entrepreneurship explain the relationship between education and entrepreneurial intention, implying that the quality of educational experience matters as much as the level of attainment.

Educational gaps can hinder youth participation in entrepreneurship. (Nur Asrina R, 2025) Found that lower educational levels are associated with higher unemployment rates among the youth workforce in North Luwu District, indicating that limited educational attainment reduces access to both employment and entrepreneurial opportunities. Local institutional initiatives, such as those by Notre Dame of Dadiangas University (2025), emphasize the need for continuous integration of entrepreneurial education in academic curricula to address this gap, preparing students for self-reliant and opportunity-driven economic participation.

Education level and entrepreneurship training are key to success in business. More education boosts knowledge, self-confidence, and innovation. This helps businesses become more sustainable and adaptable (Abulude & Ogunjemilua, 2025; Bayar et al., 2022; Wang et al., 2023). Insufficient education limits both entrepreneurial participation and job opportunities (Nur Asrina R, 2025). Thus, fostering entrepreneurship education at all levels, particularly in higher education institutions, is essential to empower young entrepreneurs with the cognitive, technical, and psychological tools required to transform ideas into sustainable ventures.

Type of Business

The resources, risks, and support systems that young entrepreneurs need depend on the kind of business they choose, whether it's manufacturing, services, retail, or social enterprise. (Hidayah et al., 2025) argue that fostering entrepreneurial skills in young people is important for addressing global economic issues and promoting sustainable development. Expanding these entrepreneurial efforts can inspire young people. This support boosts innovation and strengthens the economy. van der Westhuizen (2024) notes that many young people in South Africa work in micro- and service-sector jobs. They need money, even though these businesses need less capital

to grow. According to Verick (2023), the unemployment rate among young people is much higher than that of adults, and the majority of young workers work in informal jobs, which restricts their ability to move up the economic ladder. These studies highlight the ways in which larger societal, educational, and economic contexts influence the kinds of business that young entrepreneurs choose to pursue. In this sense, research on Filipino youth entrepreneurship in particular is essential since local conditions in these areas present particular difficulties that could influence how business endeavors develop.

Young entrepreneurs' opportunities depend on the type of business they operate. New digital platforms, rapidly evolving technology, and shifting consumer tastes have all played a role in this change. (Chinthala, 2022) looks at how digital transformation affects entrepreneurship. It focuses on creating new business models and ventures. Prabhu (2021) asserts that social enterprises, in particular, give young people the chance to solve urgent community problems while making money, thereby combining the opportunities for social impact and personal livelihood. Filipino youth businesses that adopted digital marketing during the pandemic were more resilient, demonstrating how creativity and adaptability can transform obstacles into business opportunities (Magtubo, 2022).

Nevertheless, the business model also presents unique difficulties. Finance and regulatory barriers hit product-based ventures hard. This is especially true for those needing high startup capital and strict compliance (van der Westhuizen, 2024). Young business owners in China's manufacturing sector often face pushback from employers. According to Fan (2024), young business owners in China's manufacturing sector frequently encounter resistance from employers because they lack specialized knowledge and expertise. Despite being simpler to launch, digital-based companies must contend with fierce competition and platform reliance, which may compromise their long-term viability. Similarly, (Ofosu-Appiah et al.,

2025), youth in Sub-Saharan Africa face significant barriers to launching formal businesses, including unfavorable legal systems, lack government regulations, and restricted market accessibility. The long-term viability of businesses worldwide is significantly affected by these obstacles.

Depending on the kind of business, different support networks are available for young entrepreneurs. As to (Dzakiy et al., 2025) universities offer funding, mentoring, incubators, and other forms of support at different levels. However, how well these programs fit the unique requirements of startups at every stage of their growth will determine how successful they are. Because mismatched support can result in problems like loan misuse and repayment defaults, this alignment is essential (Magsambol-Monton, 2025). These findings imply that rather than being universal, youth entrepreneurship support systems ought to be tailored to the kind of business and its stage of development.

Duration of Business Operation

Many factors influence how long a youth entrepreneur's business lasts. These include support for infrastructure, training for entrepreneurs, and strategic plans. Rudenko and Goryachikh (2020) point out that infrastructure support is key for small youth businesses to thrive and endure. Young entrepreneurs need strong support to grow their businesses after starting. Their research shows that a good infrastructure is key. This includes access to resources like funding, mentorship, and digital tools. Similarly, Orobia et al. (2020) investigate how framework conditions that promote business sustainability—like laws, training, and support networks—are essential for extending the life of companies. Their results highlight how crucial it is to establish a supportive atmosphere, particularly for young business owners, in order to guarantee that companies prosper long after their infancy.

Training and prior business experience are important determinants of the longevity of youth entrepreneurship endeavors. (Menya, 2020) looks into the effects of entrepreneurial training programs on the lifespan and productivity of micro and small businesses in Kenya. His research indicates that because training programs give young entrepreneurs the abilities and information they need to overcome early obstacles, they play a crucial role in improving the long-term viability and prosperity of these companies. Furthermore, Bignotti and Le Roux (2020) contend that in order to inspire young people to pursue entrepreneurship, prior work experience and startup experience are crucial. Their research shows that these experiences have a direct impact on how long youth-run businesses last, suggesting that business owners with experience have a higher chance of keeping their companies open for longer.

The lifespan of youth-run businesses is also significantly influenced by social media and outside networks. Social media is essential for millennial entrepreneurs, according to (Melak & Derso, 2023), because it fosters a sense of fulfillment, self-perceived creativity, and trust—all of which help businesses last longer. These networks provide a venue for market expansion, consumer interaction, and brand development—all of which support the long-term viability of startups. The effects of digital transformation on the longevity of youth-run businesses, particularly in the hospitality industry, are examined by (X. Sun et al., 2020). Their study shows that young entrepreneurs can increase the longevity of their companies by utilizing digital tools to increase customer reach, optimize workflows, and manage operations more effectively.

These studies show how personal experiences, outside help, and digital tools work together. They shape the success of youth-led businesses. Infrastructure development, digital engagement, and entrepreneurial training all work together to give young entrepreneurs the tools and information they need to overcome obstacles and succeed in cutthroat markets, which is essential to the long-term viability of these endeavors.

Business Location

The location of a business is significant for its success and long-term viability, especially for young entrepreneurs. (de Guzman et al., 2020) investigated the impact of rural communities on youth's entrepreneurial activities. Their research indicates that, despite initiatives to retain youth in rural regions, obstacles such as inadequate infrastructure and scarce resources hinder the success of youth-led enterprises in these settings. These results show how important location is for the growth of youth entrepreneurship. (Chin, 2020) also asserts that the state of the neighborhood is very important for the success of new businesses, with urban and semi-urban areas being better for them. The study shows that young entrepreneurs in these areas have better access to markets, better infrastructure, and more community involvement, which makes it easier for them to succeed than young entrepreneurs in rural areas.

(Cissé et al., 2020) Also examine how local factors, such as social capital and market access, affect where young entrepreneurs decide to start their businesses. The results indicate that proximity to supportive environments, such as mentorship networks and business hubs, is essential for entrepreneurial success. The geographical context—the availability of resources, networks, and opportunities in a specific location—significantly influences the sustainability of youth-led ventures. Similarly, (Lintang Rachmadana & Siswanto, 2021)) show how the presence of family businesses affects where young entrepreneurs choose to set up shop. They say that being near family-run businesses provides a support system that makes starting a business much easier and gives young entrepreneurs the tools they need.

In agribusiness, the economic and strategic factors that go into choosing a location are also very important. (Akrong & Kotu, 2022) Look at how location affects the success of agripreneurship in Benin. Their research indicates that youth-led agribusinesses thrive when

located near agricultural centers and marketplaces, thereby facilitating access to supplies, market opportunities, and consumer demand and enhancing their success. (Das, 2022) examines the importance of business location for young people in India. He says that young entrepreneurs are more likely to succeed in places where they can easily reach markets and access government support programs. Their research underscores how these factors facilitate financial success and long-term sustainability.

These studies show that location is vital for young people who want to start their own businesses. The reason is that it affects not only their ability to reach customers and run their businesses, but also their ability to make friends and find support. Establishing business centers, family support, government programs, and mentorship networks has a significant impact on the long-term success and growth potential of businesses run by young people.

Government programs avail

Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) are an important part of the Philippine economy because they create jobs, add to GDP, and help the economy grow in their own areas. But MSMEs have a lot of problems, such as not being able to get enough money, not knowing enough about how to run a business, and not being able to adapt to new technologies. Government programs are very important for helping MSMEs grow and deal with these problems.

The Negosyo Center is one of the most important government programs in the Philippines to help MSMEs grow. The Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) started the Negosyo Center as part of the "Go Negosyo Act." Its goal is to give small and micro businesses important services like registering their business name, training, and access to financing (Pearl & Cruz, 2024). These centers have given local business owners more power by giving them easy-to-use tools for growing their businesses. It is especially helpful for people who live in rural or underserved areas. (Pearl & Cruz, 2024) A study on the Negosyo Center in Matnog showed that the program was

effective at helping MSME owners think like entrepreneurs, leading to greater innovation and the ability to bounce back from market challenges.

Another government program that has helped MSMEs in poor areas is the Livelihood Seeding Program—Negosyo Serbisyo Barangay (LSP-NSB). The LSP-NSB's primary goal is to help micro and small businesses, especially those affected by natural and economic disasters, by providing funding and supporting their growth (Dordas, 2024). DTI has put this program into action, and it looks like it will help businesses get better access to markets, improve their management skills, and promote sustainable business practices. But problems like not enough money, not enough monitoring, and not having long-term help have been found to be major obstacles to the program's success.

Several studies also stressed the importance of technology for MSMEs. (Cueto et al., 2022b) Found that MSMEs' move to digital platforms during economic disruptions like the COVID-19 pandemic was very important for their survival. The study showed that young entrepreneurs were especially good at using digital tools, which helped their businesses keep going and even grow during lockdowns and other market disruptions. Digital technologies are not only a way for MSMEs to stay in business but also to grow. The fact that e-commerce is still the most popular way to shop online makes this even more true.

Also, MSMEs often have trouble getting money, which is a big problem for them. Research, including Dordas ' (2024) assessment of the Livelihood Seeding Program, indicates that financial obstacles persist as a significant concern. Even though there are programs that give MSMEs livelihood kits and money, they still have trouble getting enough capital to grow their businesses and compete with bigger companies.

Government programs like Negosyo Centers and LSP-NSB have aided MSMEs in many ways. However, more support is needed to tackle challenges in capital, training, and technology.

MSMEs must adopt digital tools. They also need easier access to financing and better support systems. This will help them thrive in today's digital and competitive world. The MSME Development Plan 2023-2028 and other plans aim to improve conditions for small businesses. They also focus on making the economy more open.

YOUTH ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Youth entrepreneurship is gaining recognition worldwide. It's seen as a smart answer to ongoing youth unemployment and underemployment. It also responds to the changing job landscape. The World Youth Report (2020), says that youth entrepreneurship is complex. It needs technical and management skills, but also creativity, resilience, and personal drive. This viewpoint emphasizes that technical or managerial skills and personal drive are essential for entrepreneurial success, presenting it as a multifaceted process rather than just an economic endeavor.

From a developmental standpoint, the entrepreneurial journey is framed by UNICEF (2020) as a phased process that begins with an idea, which starts up and progresses through early development and growth. Each stage requires distinct forms of support, ranging from mentorship and capacity-building to financial access and market connections. This method highlights the fact that entrepreneurship is a dynamic process that is influenced by changing opportunities and challenges rather than a one-time occurrence. Similarly, Youth Business International and Global Entrepreneurship Network (2024) broaden this perspective by defining four pillars that are critical to the development of youth enterprises: growth support, pipeline development, an enabling business environment, and financial accessibility. These pillars give practitioners and policymakers a well-organized framework for creating interventions that address the various needs of young entrepreneurs.

Youth Entrepreneurship is the process of creating value by spotting and seizing opportunities through innovation Entrepreneurs Data (2024). This definition is characterized by

its ability to solve problems and seize opportunities. Young entrepreneurs require different kinds of support because they may be motivated by opportunity or necessity, and their ventures can range from supporting to growth-oriented enterprises or those forced by external factors (Entrepreneurship Monitor, 2025). As a result, individual goals, institutional structures, and general social and economic circumstances all have an impact on youth entrepreneurship.

Government Programs

Government initiatives are well known for giving young entrepreneurs essential support in the form of funding, mentorship, and training. However, a number of factors, such as how well these programs address long-term sustainability and the expansion of youth enterprises beyond the initial startup phase, will determine how effective they are. Boris & Parakhina (2022), contend that combining government assistance with private sector initiatives greatly increases the likelihood of success for young enterprises, particularly in areas with little funding. Their findings support the notion that government initiatives that provide networking opportunities and financial support can assist young entrepreneurs in creating robust enterprises.

Even as these programs provide vital early support, helping businesses grow remains challenging. As (Sukumar et al., 2022) state, government initiatives aimed at promoting social entrepreneurship have made significant progress in assisting young people in addressing social issues via business in nations such as Indonesia. However, as these companies expand, their research shows a significant gap in the support offered for innovation and market expansion. This highlights the need for a more comprehensive strategy that includes tactics to support businesses' expansion and sustainability in addition to business startup.

Government programs have helped many young people start businesses. But there are still gaps in support for their growth and long-term success. Many programs, like Youth

Empowerment through Technopreneurship (YET), offer resources and seed funding. But scalable solutions for expanding businesses are still limited. Danns & Danns (2022), say young entrepreneurs struggle to find quality financial advice and mentoring while building their businesses. It also aligns with Prasannath et al. (2024b), who advocate greater focus on scalable funding and creative mentorship initiatives to help companies grow beyond their initial stages. They point out that long-term plans that expand corporate operations while maintaining sustainability should be incorporated into government programs.

Furthermore, it is becoming clearer that sector-specific government policies are necessary because these industries face specific challenges, (Prasannath et al., 2024b; Sukumar et al., 2022) emphasize the importance of tailored support for young entrepreneurs in industries such as technology and social entrepreneurship. For example, young people in the technology industry need programs that give them access to opportunities for market expansion and cutting-edge innovation. In contrast, those involved in social entrepreneurship need policies that encourage the establishment of new businesses and their growth to achieve greater social impact. These sectoral differences are frequently ignored by the one-size-fits-all approach used in many government programs today, thereby reducing the effectiveness of assistance for young entrepreneurs.

The literature shows that more work is needed to address the long-term needs of young entrepreneurs, particularly in scaling, innovation, and sector-specific support, even though government programs have been successful in helping young people launch businesses. There is growing agreement in the literature that government initiatives should go beyond starting new businesses and incorporate mentorship, long-term support systems, and scalable growth strategies. Additionally, more focus should be put on creating programs specifically for young entrepreneurs in a variety of industries, particularly technology and social enterprises, and integrating local government capabilities with national initiatives.

Digital platforms and tools

Digital tools and platforms have quickly changed the way young entrepreneurs run and grow their businesses. These platforms are now necessary for overcoming problems such as limited resources, insufficient customer reach, and poor business visibility. Many young business owners don't have much money and can't access traditional business resources. However, platforms like social media, e-commerce, and online collaboration tools make it easier to reach global markets, lower costs, and improve business performance.

As (Mavlutova et al., 2025) that digital platforms bring together digital tools and applications that governments and businesses use to communicate, manage, transfer knowledge, network and collaborate. These tools not only help young people become more interested in starting their own businesses, but they also give them access to funding opportunities. The study shows that digital tools, mainly when used in schools, help young entrepreneurs make decisions and plan, thereby helping them navigate the challenges of the digital economy. It's especially useful for business owners in poor countries, where digital platforms are necessary to compensate for limited resources and market access.

In the same way, Mia et al. (2024) demonstrate that social media and e-commerce sites were essential for micro, small, and medium-sized businesses (MSMEs) during the COVID-19 pandemic. Their study showed that young business owners who used digital tools such as social media for marketing and video conferencing for client meetings managed during hard times by using digital tools. Others who didn't use digital platforms had a hard time. This change shows how adaptable and powerful digital tools can be, especially when unexpected problems arise.

(Shahzady, 2024) makes another point about how social media sites like Facebook and Instagram can change the lives of young Pakistani entrepreneurs. These platforms help young business owners who don't have much money by lowering marketing costs and enabling them to

reach more people. This, in turn, helps people become loyal to a brand and build long-term relationships with customers. This shows that social media is not just a marketing tool but also a strategic resource for small businesses to grow and stay in business.

These platforms do have some advantages, but there are still problems, especially around getting people to use them and the digital divide. According to research by de Klerk et al. (2025), young entrepreneurs in developing countries use social media to reach more customers, but a lack of digital skills remains a significant challenge. Sri Lankan youth entrepreneurs have been able to break into international markets with the help of social media. But the study admits that digital literacy and technical training are still lacking, which means that these platforms can't reach their full potential.

Digital Entrepreneurial Education (DEE) is another important factor that stands out as helping people want to start their own businesses. (Duong et al., 2024)found that DEE is very important for helping young entrepreneurs improve their digital skills and self-esteem, which makes them more likely to start a digital business. This educational framework helps young people feel less anxious about technology and gives them the freedom to look into different online business models. (Lopes et al., 2025) supported this by stating that teaching young people about digital entrepreneurship helps them be more creative and adapt quickly to the digital economy, equipping them with the skills they need to succeed in the digital world.

Even though digital platforms have a positive effect, we still don't fully understand how personality traits affect the success of digital entrepreneurs. (Medfouni et al., 2024) argue that more research is needed on how personal traits, such as innovation and a willingness to take risks, affect the use of digital tools and business success. (Usman & Sun, 2023) contend that having a strategy is very important for startups using digital platforms to succeed. They say that having a clear plan helps young business owners get the most out of digital tools like social media and e-

commerce, especially when there is a lot of competition. This suggests that digital platforms offer a lot of potential, but you need to have a good plan in place to make the most of them.

Digital platforms aren't just tools. They are vital for young entrepreneurs to succeed, especially in developing economies. The literature shows these tools have great potential. However, obstacles remain, particularly in digital literacy and planning. Future studies should look into how education and training can help young entrepreneurs make the most of the digital tools they have. More research should examine how personal traits and digital platforms interact. This will help us understand their effects on business outcomes better.

Limited access to capital

Globally, one of the most significant problems young entrepreneurs face is limited access to capital, which limits their business sustainability. (Sunandes et al., 2025) Affirmed that SMEs persistently face significant obstacles in securing capital and adapting to digital finance, despite their essential function in promoting economic resilience. This problem is especially severe in places where the financial system isn't weak and credit isn't hard to obtain. The (Asian Development Bank (ADB, 2023) also noted that many Filipino micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) have trouble getting financing because of strict collateral requirements, high interest rates, and a lack of access to formal credit mechanisms. These problems make it hard for young entrepreneurs to grow their businesses and get the resources they need for long-term growth.

(Kumarasamy et al., 2025) conducted a study on government initiatives for youth entrepreneurship, revealing that financial access is particularly constrained in rural areas. Their research showed that even when they focus on certain demographic groups, people in areas with stronger economies have better access to financial resources. This finding aligns with the (International Trade Centre, 2022)

During the COVID-19 pandemic, young business owners in Legazpi City mostly relied on their own money, which made it very hard for them to keep their businesses going and grow them (Llamasares, 2023). (Batizani & Ronald Neva, 2024) also found that young entrepreneurs in Malawi often get most of their money from family loans and microfinance institutions. The study reveals that there are few official methods for young people to secure funding for their businesses.

A study conducted by (Notre Dame of Dadiangas University, 2025) revealed that young entrepreneurs in General Santos City regarded financial management as one of their primary challenges, especially in relation to acquiring and efficiently overseeing capital. These problems are made worse by structural barriers like limited access to credit and complicated regulations. (Conception, 2021) pointed out that young Filipino entrepreneurs have trouble getting money, technology, and market support, which keeps them from moving from small businesses to long-term ones. (Sevillo et al., 2024) also found that small business owners in Iloilo have a hard time because of strict collateral requirements and complicated rules, which shows that the problem is systemic.

These findings collectively demonstrate the intricate challenges that young entrepreneurs encounter in obtaining capital and navigating financial systems. To make sure that youth-led businesses can grow and thrive, we need to fix some big problems, such as the fact that most funding opportunities are in cities, that young people rely on personal or informal loans, and that they can't get to formal financial institutions.

Poor Market Access and Infrastructure

Young entrepreneurs, especially in rural and developing areas, face big challenges. Limited market access and poor infrastructure are key obstacles. Entrepreneurship boosts rural development, but young entrepreneurs struggle to succeed. They face challenges in scaling their

businesses and reaching new markets. This often happens because of bad road conditions, spotty internet, and slow transit systems. (Nautiyal & Kameswari, 2025) point out that rural youth struggle to grow their businesses outside their communities. These obstacles include poor transportation, which limits young entrepreneurs. Their research highlights how inadequate infrastructure restricts young entrepreneurs' access to information, technology, and training, and limits mobility and distribution channels. Akbar and Wijaya (2024) found that young people in Indonesia struggle to use digital tools for business. This is because digital infrastructure is unevenly spread between urban and rural areas. Rural communities struggle with unstable internet and low digital skills. This makes it tough for them to join the market, even with their strong cultural values and ethics.

(Olalekan, 2024), observes that while digital technologies have generated new opportunities for rural entrepreneurship, challenges such as limited internet access, unreliable power supply, and insufficient digital skills persist. These problems cause a "digital divide" that impacts competitiveness and market reach by separating entrepreneurs in rural and urban areas. (Soumyashree N Hegde, 2025) Similarly, it observes that rural entrepreneurs in India are unable to access online marketplaces and digital payment systems due to a lack of technological infrastructure. Although many entrepreneurs have expressed interest in using technology to promote local products, her research shows that the lack of dependable internet and devices prevents rural businesses from fully engaging in the digital economy. These results demonstrate that although technology has the potential to overcome market barriers, its benefits are frequently undermined by limited access and digital skills.

Furthermore, Iqbal (2025) emphasizes that women entrepreneurs in developing economies are also impacted by inadequate institutional support and inadequate infrastructure. According to her review of women's entrepreneurship in Pakistan, women's

ability to launch and grow businesses is hampered by structural obstacles like poor access to market facilities, a lack of business spaces, and inadequate transportation. The study also shows that social constraints and hard access to capital frequently exacerbate these physical barriers, demonstrating how a number of factors work together to make market access even more difficult for women and young business owners. In a related vein, Nadeem et al. (2025) highlight that inadequate supply chains and subpar logistical systems pose challenges for small business owners in rural regions. According to his research, entrepreneurs are restricted to small, unofficial markets in the absence of adequate government attention to infrastructure and market connectivity, which hinders their ability to expand their businesses and stabilize their income.

Although most studies agree that infrastructure is an essential starting point for entrepreneurship, some highlight new developments. For example, (Akbar & Wijaya, 2024; Olalekan, 2024) suggest that, with support from public and private sector initiatives, advancements in digital literacy and infrastructure can help close some market gaps. However, even with these advancements, systemic inequality between rural and urban areas remains at the heart of infrastructure and market access issues. Furthermore, not much research has been done on long-term strategies that combine digital and physical infrastructure to support inclusive entrepreneurship.

Overall, the research shows that inadequate infrastructure and limited market access continue to be major obstacles to young entrepreneurs worldwide. Although educational programs and digital technologies present promising tools, their influence is constrained in the absence of reliable financial systems, transportation networks, and connectivity. In order to ensure that young entrepreneurs can access larger markets and compete more successfully in the modern economy, future research should examine how local governments and the private sector can collaborate to improve both physical and digital infrastructure.

Low Financial and Business Literacy

Low financial and business literacy is a major obstacle that young entrepreneurs must overcome in order to manage resources, make wise decisions, and guarantee the long-term viability of their businesses. According to Sequeira (2020), young entrepreneurs in India's rural areas frequently lack financial knowledge and education, which hinders their capacity to efficiently manage funds and business operations. Young people are ill-prepared to handle the financial challenges of running a business because the educational system in many places, including rural ones, tends to prioritize salaried jobs over preparing people for entrepreneurship.

As defined by the (OECD, 2025) financial literacy is the set of abilities and information needed to make wise financial decisions. It is essential to the accomplishment of youth-led projects. (Duvenhage et al., 2025) found that individuals with higher financial literacy are more likely to engage in effective savings behaviors, which is essential not only for personal financial security but also for managing business finances. Many young business owners struggle with investments, credit, and budgeting. This often happens because they lack financial skills. This can result in poor financial management and, in the end, business failure.

A lack of financial and business literacy also limits the impact of microfinance and digital finance initiatives. (Angeles, 2022) discovered that although digital financial tools, like mobile money services, have a lot of potential to enhance financial practices, their effectiveness depends on their combination with financial literacy. Young entrepreneurs are unable to optimize the potential of available financial resources if they do not know how to use these tools effectively, which results in inefficient capital use and unsustainable business practices.

(Lila Maria Kaban et al., 2023) Argue that financial literacy is crucial for improving financial decision-making and achieving business success among young entrepreneurs, thereby reinforcing

the importance of financial literacy education. They say that teaching young entrepreneurs about money management could make them much better at handling their money, which would lead to businesses that last longer. Munyuki and Jonah (2022) also stress how important it is to be financially literate in order to be successful as an entrepreneur, especially in low-income areas where money problems are more common. Their research shows that young business owners who don't know much about money have a hard time managing their finances, which makes it less likely that they will be able to grow and be successful.

A significant structural barrier that restricts young people's ability to start their own businesses, especially in rural and developing areas, is a lack of financial and business literacy. Microfinance services and digital financial tools can be very helpful, but without enough financial education, they often do not work as well as they could. To address this problem, entrepreneurship education programs, especially in poor areas, should include financial literacy to help young entrepreneurs access and use capital effectively.

1.3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

The study on Opportunities and Challenges of Youth Entrepreneurs will use the following frameworks: Entrepreneurial Opportunity Recognition Theory and the Resource-Based View. These theories provide a clear explanation of how youth entrepreneurs identify opportunities and how they face challenges in their ventures. These serve as guides to understanding the opportunities and challenges that shape youth entrepreneurship.

Entrepreneurial Opportunity Recognition Theory

This study, anchored on the Entrepreneurial Opportunity Recognition Theory proposed by (Baron, 2006), suggest that entrepreneurs are more likely to succeed when they can recognize and act on opportunities in their environment. For youth entrepreneurs, this means using creativity, digital tools, and awareness of market trends to identify business ideas. (Alzate et al., 2024) emphasized that young people are adaptive and innovative, which allows them to respond quickly to emerging needs. This theory supports the “opportunities” aspect of the study by showing how recognition skills help youth turn ideas into viable businesses.

Resource-Based View (RBV)

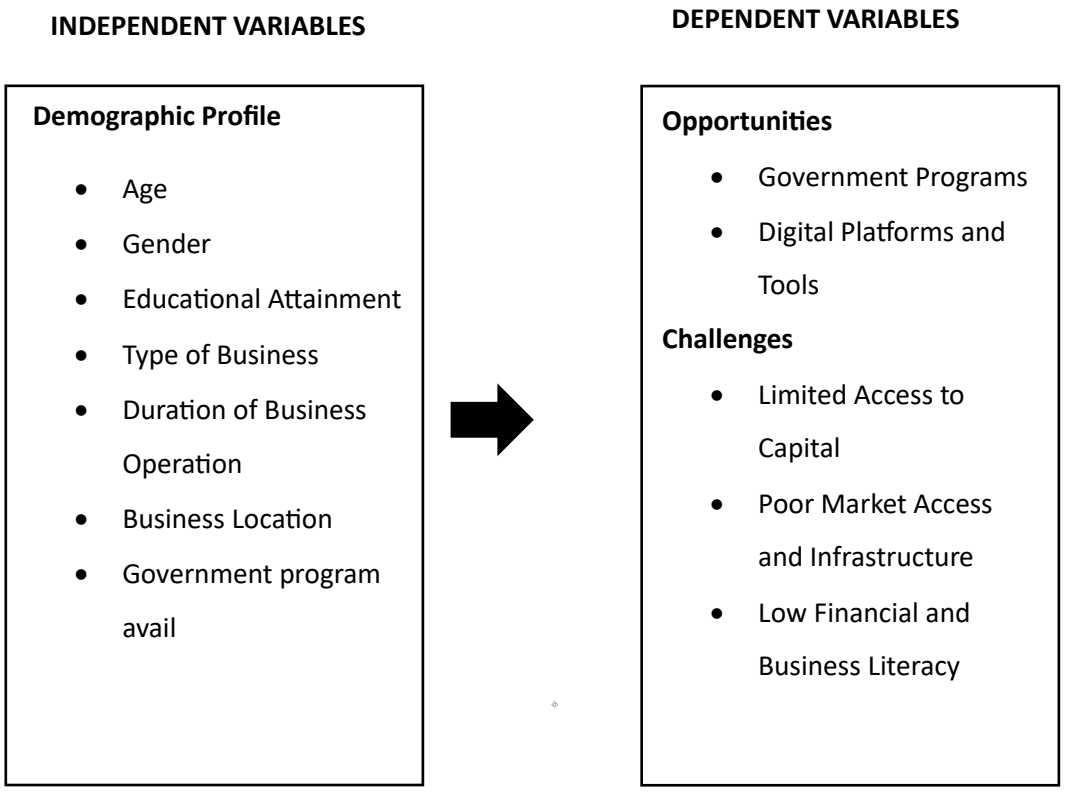
Explains that a business’s success depends on its internal resources and how effectively these are used (Barney, 1991). RBV highlights that when resources such as capital, skills, and networks are strong, entrepreneurs are more likely to sustain and grow their ventures. However, when these resources are limited, challenges arise. For youth entrepreneurs, this often means difficulty in accessing financial support, relying instead on personal savings or family assistance (Kumarasamy et al., 2025).

(Nadeem et al., 2025) Stated that limited market access and poor infrastructure create significant barriers for youth entrepreneurs, particularly in rural areas, as these conditions reduce their ability to reach customers and deliver products efficiently. This highlights how structural

challenges in the business environment directly constrain entrepreneurial growth, even when opportunities exist. Entrepreneurs, guided by RBV, focus on leveraging their distinctive strengths to uncover opportunities aligned with their core competencies. This approach encourages entrepreneurs to identify opportunities where their resources provide them with a competitive edge (Laxmi Prabha, 2023).

In conclusion, the Entrepreneurial Opportunity Recognition Theory and the Resource-Based View (RBV) provide complementary perspectives on how youth entrepreneurs navigate the dual forces of opportunity and constraint. By recognizing opportunities and leveraging available resources, youth entrepreneurs can overcome the challenges of limited capital and poor infrastructure, ultimately leading to business success and growth. The study highlights that while recognizing opportunities is important, having access to sufficient resources, infrastructure, and support is equally significant for youth entrepreneurs to thrive.

1.4 SCHEMATIC DIAGRAM



1.5 Statement of the Problem

This study aims to investigate the opportunities and challenges of the youth entrepreneurs in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. It focuses on individuals aged 18-35 who have been operating their businesses for at least six months to over one year. It also seeks to understand how government programs support youth entrepreneurship in these areas. Specifically, this study addresses the following objectives:

1. What is the demographic profile of youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in terms of:
   1.1 Age;
   1.2 Gender;
   1.3 Educational Attainment;
   1.4 Type of Business;
   1.5 Duration of business operation;
   1.6 Business Location; and
   1.7 Government programs avail?
2. What is the level of opportunities for youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in terms of:
   2.1 Government programs; and
   2.2 Digital platforms and tools?
3. What are the levels of challenges that limit the growth and sustainability of youth entrepreneurship in these municipalities in terms of:
   3.1 Limited access to capital;
   3.2 Poor Market Access and Infrastructure; and
   3.3 Low Financial and Business Literacy?

4. Is there a significant relationship between the opportunities and challenges of the youth entrepreneurs?

1.6 Hypothesis

H_0: There is no significant relationship between the opportunities and challenges of the youth entrepreneurs.

H_1: There is a significant relationship between the opportunities and challenges of the youth entrepreneurs.

1.7 Scope and Limitation

This study is limited to youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BUENASCAR), Agusan del Norte, who are beneficiaries of national and local government programs such as the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) and Negosyo Centers. Only youth-owned businesses that have been in operation for at least six months to one year or above are included. Data will be gathered directly from these respondents using structured questionnaires to capture their experiences on opportunities and challenges in relation to the effectiveness of the government support for youth entrepreneurs.

This study focuses only on youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BUENASCAR) and does not include those from other areas in Agusan del Norte. Because of this, the results may not reflect the experiences of youth entrepreneurs in other regions or those not involved in government support programs. Data were gathered through structured survey questionnaires, relying on participants' self-reported answers, which could be influenced by bias or incomplete information. The research does not look at long-term entrepreneurial outcomes or consider outside influences like national economic trends or changes in the global market.

1.8 Definition of Terms

The following terms and words are operationally defined to facilitate comprehension and classification:

Agusan del Norte. The study examines the opportunities and challenges faced by youth entrepreneurs in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, a province in the Caraga region of Mindanao, Philippines.

Age. Refers to the number of years an individual has lived, specifically focusing on youth entrepreneurs aged 18-35 in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, and how age influences their entrepreneurial experiences and challenges.

Business Location. The municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte serve as the primary locations for youth entrepreneurship. The local context in these municipalities influences youth entrepreneurs' access to resources, infrastructure, and market opportunities.

Challenges. Refers to the obstacles faced by youth entrepreneurs in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, such as limited access to capital, poor market infrastructure, and low business literacy, which hinder their business growth.

Digital Platforms and Tools. Refers to online resources, such as social media, e-commerce platforms, and digital marketing tools, that youth entrepreneurs use to manage and promote their businesses in the municipalities.

Duration of Business Operation. Refers to the length of time a youth entrepreneur has been operating their business, specifically those with at least six months to one year of experience, and how this affects their business practices and challenges.

Educational Attainment. The study examines the highest level of formal education completed by youth entrepreneurs and how education influences their business knowledge, decision-making, and access to resources in municipalities.

Entrepreneurship. Refers to the process of establishing, managing, and growing a business venture, particularly by youth in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, and the challenges and opportunities that accompany the entrepreneurial journey.

Gender. Refers to the social and cultural roles assigned to individuals based on their sex (male, female, or non-binary), and how these roles influence the entrepreneurial opportunities and challenges faced by youth in the municipalities.

Government Programs. Refers to the initiatives, grants, and policies provided by the government to support youth entrepreneurs, such as financial assistance, training, and incentives, and how they affect the business operations of youth in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen.

Limited Access to Capital. Refers to the challenge that youth entrepreneurs face in securing adequate financial resources needed to start or expand their businesses, particularly in the municipalities studied.

Low Financial and Business Literacy. Refers to the lack of knowledge in financial management and business practices that limits decision-making and success among youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen.

Opportunities. The potential for growth and success that youth entrepreneurs can exploit includes access to government programs, new markets, and digital tools to overcome challenges and expand their businesses.

Poor market Access and Infrastructure. Refers to the difficulties that youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen face due to inadequate infrastructure and limited access to markets, which restrict their ability to grow and reach customers.

Type of Business. Refers to the industry or sector in which youth entrepreneurs operate, such as retail, service, or technology, and how the type of business influences the challenges and opportunities encountered by young business owners.

Youth Entrepreneurs. Refers to individuals ages 18-35 who establish and operate businesses in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, and whose entrepreneurial experiences and challenges are the focus of this study.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

This chapter discussed the research design, locale, respondents, instruments, ethical considerations, and data gathering procedures. It also describes the materials and instruments utilized, outlining how the researchers collected the necessary data.

2.1 Research Design

This study will employ a quantitative research design as it involves collecting and analyzing numerical data from the responses of youth entrepreneurs regarding the opportunities and challenges they encounter. It utilized a descriptive research method, which systematically describes the characteristics of a population, situation, or phenomenon without manipulating variables (McCombes, 2023). Its goal is to provide an accurate account of the demographic profile, opportunities, and challenges of youth entrepreneurs in Agusan del Norte. Furthermore, descriptive research is widely applied in entrepreneurship studies because it captures present conditions and generates baseline data that can guide policies and programs (Bhandari, 2022).

2.2 Research Locale

The study will take place in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte. These areas were chosen as the research sites because they include youth entrepreneurs aged 18-35 who manage micro and small enterprises and benefit from programs of the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) and Negosyo Centers. This locale serves as the setting for examining the opportunities accessible to young entrepreneurs as well as the challenges they encounter in sustaining their businesses.

2.3 Research Respondents

The study's respondents were youth entrepreneurs from the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte. To obtain the necessary data, the researchers will

administer a survey questionnaire in person and employ a stratified random sampling method to ensure representation across key subgroups.

Table 1. Distribution of the Respondents

RESPONDENTS (YOUTH ENTREPRENEURS)	Population	Sample	
	F	f	%
BUENAVISTA	20	18	35.09
NASIPIT	15	13	26.32
CARMEN	22	19	38.59
Total	**57**	**50**	**100.0**

Sample Size: 35

2.4 Research Instrument

This study will use a self-developed survey designed to collect data aligned with the research objectives, focusing on opportunities, challenges, and interrelationships relevant to youth entrepreneurs. The research team developed survey indicators based on an extensive review of relevant academic literature. To ensure accuracy and reliability, the survey will undergo validation and pilot testing to evaluate clarity, relevance, and consistency with the study's aims. The research team will incorporate revisions informed by pilot study feedback prior to the final distribution of materials.

2.5 Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

Ensuring that all outputs, including tools or analytical models produced, were protected under Philippine copyright law, this research upheld the provisions of the Intellectual Property Code of the Philippines (RA No. 8293). Proper acknowledgements were given to all authors, researchers, and institutions whose work contributed to the development of this research. All literature, instruments, and resources used are duly cited to avoid plagiarism and ensure academic

honesty. Throughout the research process, the researchers ensured compliance with intellectual property rights and academic integrity.

B. Informed Consent

This study involved youth entrepreneurs from Agusan del Norte, specifically in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Before participating, respondents were fully informed about the purpose, procedures, and nature of the study. Written consents were used to ensure that the respondents fully understood their rights, including the freedom to withdraw or decline at any time without negative consequences.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

This study ensured the protection of participants' personal information by adhering to the Philippines' Data Privacy Act of 2012 (RA 10173). All data gathered from respondents was handled with the highest level of confidentiality. Personal identities were removed to protect the participants' privacy, and all the data were only used for academic purposes.

D. Voluntary Participation

Participation in the study was entirely voluntary which are all respondents were properly informed of their rights to decline or discontinue participation without any consequences. No participants were forced to take part.

E. Minimization of Harm

A detailed evaluation of potential risks was conducted to ensure that no physical, psychological, emotional, or social harm came to participants. Surveys were distributed to youth entrepreneurs at their respective business locations, with the researchers present to monitor the process and provide assistance if needed.

F. Beneficence

This study seeks to benefit the community by deepening understanding of the opportunities and challenges faced by youth entrepreneurs. The study's findings may serve as a basis for improving entrepreneurship programs and policies that empower youth entrepreneurs.

G. Justice and Fair Participation Selection

The respondents of the study were youth entrepreneurs from Agusan del Norte, specifically in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. To ensure fairness and inclusivity, the researchers identified the participants by requesting official lists of youth entrepreneurs from the said municipalities. Using stratified sampling, participants were selected by business type, ensuring that each subgroup of youth entrepreneurs was proportionally represented in the study.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

The researchers will collect and analyze data using reliable methods to ensure accurate results. All information collected will be handled truthfully and accurately. The researchers will report the findings based on actual results obtained from the study.

I. Transparency in Reporting

The researchers maintain transparency throughout the study by accurately presenting the methods, data collected, analyses, and results without manipulation. Limitations are also disclosed to provide a balance and honest representation of the research outcomes.

J. Use of Patented or Copyright Materials

The researcher secured permissions before using any patented or copyrighted materials. Proper credit was given to the rightful owners of such intellectual properties. Materials were only used strictly for academic purposes.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

The participants were fully informed about any potential risks and benefits associated with the study. This study does not involve animal or clinical human trials. For the participants, ethical guidelines were strictly observed to protect the participants' rights and well-being throughout the research process.

L. Responsible use of AI and Related Technologies

The researchers will employ AI tools and digital techniques that will be used as part of the study, such as data processing, which will be applied responsibly and ethically. The researchers ensured transparency in disclosing their use and avoiding any form of academic dishonesty.

M. Ethical Approval

Before data collection, the study will obtain ethical approval from the Ethics Review Committee at Saint Michael College of Caraga, ensuring that it adheres to institutional and all relevant guidelines.

Data Gathering Procedures

The researcher will coordinate with local government units (LGUs), DTI, and Negosyo Center offices to access lists of youth entrepreneur beneficiaries in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. After securing formal approval, a structured survey will be distributed either in printed form or via Google Forms, depending on the respondent's accessibility. Informed consent will be obtained, and confidentiality will be assured. Data collection will be conducted over two weeks, with daily monitoring to ensure coverage. Completed surveys will be validated, encoded, and analyzed.

Statistical Treatment

The study will employ a quantitative data analysis on data obtained from survey questionnaires. This study utilizes the following statistical tools.

Frequency and Percentage. To determine how many youth entrepreneurs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen are aware of or using government programs and digital platforms, allowing the study to identify which opportunities are available and how widely they are accessed.

Weighted Mean. Used to measure the overall perception of youth entrepreneurs regarding specific challenges such as limited capital, market access, and financial literacy, providing a way to rank these challenges based on their perceived severity.

Mann-Whitney U test. To compare two groups (like male vs. female entrepreneurs) to see if they experience different levels of challenges or opportunities.

Kruskal-Wallis H Test. Used to examine differences among three or more groups (e.g., educational levels, type of business, or locations) in terms of their perceptions of opportunities and challenges, which helps identify which groups face greater difficulties or have access to more support.

Spearman's Rank Correlation. To determine whether there is a significant relationship between the availability of opportunities (e.g., access to government programs and digital platforms) and the level of challenges experienced, and whether existing support systems help reduce entrepreneurial difficulties.

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